

The Dhāraṇī Called the Noble Nīlakaṇṭha

Ārya-Nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 697 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble Nīlakaṇṭha Dhāraṇī, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Phags pa Nī la kaṇ ṭha zhes bya ba'i gzungs, is a dhāraṇī text centered on the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara in his form as Nīlakaṇṭha, the "blue-throated one," a name evoking both his connection to Tantric iconography and his boundless compassion for sentient beings. The text opens with a series of reverent homages — to the Three Jewels, to the buddha Amitābha, and above all to Avalokiteśvara as Lord of the World — framing the dhāraṇī within a devotional context oriented toward the cultivation of wisdom, compassion, and skillful means. As a dhāraṇī scripture, it belongs to the broader genre of ritual and mantra literature preserved in the Kangyur, where such texts are prized for their protective and spiritually transformative power. It is catalogued as Toh 697 in the Kangyur, situated among the dhāraṇī collections of that canon.

In the language of India: Ārya-Nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The dhāraṇī called the Noble Nīlakaṇṭha.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Homage to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha Amitābha.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being who has attained great power.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely attain the eye of great wisdom.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, endowed with great compassion. May I surely come to protect all sentient beings completely.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely and swiftly attain mastery in skillful means.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of great compassion. May I surely and swiftly board the vessel of great wisdom.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely and swiftly cross beyond the ocean of suffering.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely be endowed with the feet of miraculous power and swiftly attain the path.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely and swiftly ascend the mountain of nirvāṇa.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely and swiftly dwell in the house of the unconditioned.

Homage to you, the venerable Avalokiteśvara, Lord of the World, possessor of compassion. May I surely and swiftly become one with the dharmakāya.

Whenever I approach the mountain of swords, may that mountain of swords spontaneously crumble and collapse. Whenever I approach a bed of embers, may those embers spontaneously cease to exist. Whenever I approach the path to the hells, may the hells themselves be spontaneously emptied of their intrinsic nature. Whenever I approach the realm of Yama, the Lord of Death, may the hungry ghosts there be spontaneously satisfied. Whenever I approach the abode of the asuras, may their minds be spontaneously tamed. Whenever I approach the animals, may they spontaneously attain great primordial wisdom.

Namo ratnatrayāya. Namō ārya-Avalokiteśvarāya bodhisattvāya
mahāsattvāya mahākāruṇikāya. Sarva-bandhana-cchedana-kārāya.
Sarva-pāpa-samudroṣaṇa-kārāya. Sarva-vyādhi-praśamana-kārāya.
Sarva-ityupadrava-vināśana-kārāya. Sarva-bhayeṣu-tāraṇāya. Tasya
namaskṛtvā. Idaṃ ārya-Avalokiteśvarāya tava nīlakaṇṭha-nāma-paramaṃ
hṛdayam āvartayiṣyāmi. Sarva-artha-sāadhanam śubha-cetanam yan.
Sarva-bhūtānāṃ pāpa-mārga-viśodhakam. Tadyathā:
ālokeālokeāloka-adhivate. Lokātikrānte. Ehy ehi mahābodhisattva. He
bodhisattva. He mahābodhisattva. He priyabodhisattva. He mahākāruṇika.
Mahā-smara hṛdayam ehy ehi ārya-Avalokiteśvarāya
parama-maitrī-citta-kāruṇika. Kuru kuru. Karma sādahaya sādahaya. Vidyānam.
Dehi dehi me. Raṃ gama gama. Vihaṃgama. Siddha-yogīśvara. Dhuru dhuru.
Vīryante. Mahāvīryante. Dhara dhara. Dhareṃdreśvara. Cala cala.
Vimala-mūrte. Ārya-Avalokiteśvara. Kṛṣṇa-jina. Jaṭāmukuṭālaṃkṛta.
Śarīra-lamba-pralamba-vilamba. Mahāsiddha-vidyādhara. Bala bala mahābala.
Mala mala mahāmala. Cala cala mahācala. Kṛṣṇa-varṇa.
Kṛṣṇa-pakṣa-kṛṣṇa-pāśa-nirghātana. He padmahasta.

Cara cara. Niścāreśvara. Kṛṣṇa-sarva-kṛtayajño. Babhīta. Ehy ehi mahāvīra. Mahāvārāhamukha-tripura-dahaneśvara. Nārāyaṇa. Rūpabala-vegadhari. He nīlakaṇṭha. Ehy ehi mahā-hala-hala. Viṣa-nirjita. Lokasya rāga-viṣa-vināśana. Dveṣa-viṣa-vināśana. Moha-viṣa-vināśana. Nirmokṣaṇa. Hulu hulu. Mahā-hulu-hare. Mahāpadmanābhi. Sara sara. Siri siri. Suru suru. Buddhya buddhya. Bodhaya bodhaya. Bodhayāmi — ta vānīlakaṇṭha. Ehy ehi. Vāmasthita-mahāsiddha-mukha. Hasa hasa. Muñca muñca mahātṭātṭāhāsyā. Ehy ehi mahāsiddha. Yogīśvara. Bhaṇa bhaṇa. Vācana. Sādhaya sādahaya. Vidhyaṃ smara smara tvam — Bhagavantam. Lokānuvilokitam. Tathāgatam. Dehi dehi me darśanaṃ kāmasya. Darśanam. Prasādhaya me svāhā. Siddhāya svāhā. Mahāsiddhāya svāhā. Siddha-yogīśvarāya svāhā. Nīlakaṇṭhāya svāhā. Vārāhamukhāya svāhā. Siddhamukhāya svāhā. Mahānarasimhamukhāya svāhā. Vajrahastāya svāhā. Mahāvajrahastāya svāhā. Siddhi-vidyādhārāya svāhā. Mahāsiddha-vidyādhārāya svāhā. Padmahastāya svāhā. Mahāpadmahastāya svāhā. Kṛṣṇa-sarva-kṛha-yajño-dhara-vitāya svāhā. Mahāmāla-mukūṭadharāya svāhā. Cakrāyudhadharāya svāhā. Śaṅkha-śabda-nirnadana-karāya svāhā. Bodhanakarāya svāhā. Vāmasthita-skandha-deśa-kṛṣṇa-jināya svāhā. Vyāghracarma-nivāsanāya svāhā. Lokeśvarāya svāhā. Mahāyogīnīśvarāya svāhā. Sarvasiddheśvarāya svāhā. Rakṣa rakṣa mām svāhā. Kuru rakṣa mūrtinām svāhā. Namas āryāvalokiteśvarāya. Bodhisattvāya. Mahāsattvāya. Mahākāruṇikāya. Siddhyantu me mantrapadāni svāhā.

This concludes the dhāraṇī of the noble Nīlakaṇṭha.

Translator's Notes

- The passage is the opening section of the Nīlakaṇṭha Dhāraṇī, one of the most widely disseminated dhāraṇīs associated with Avalokiteśvara. The Sanskrit mantra portion from "Namo ratnatrayāya" onward is rendered directly in transliteration rather than translated, as is standard practice for dhāraṇī and mantra literature, where the sonic integrity of the text is primary. Minor scribal variations in the Tibetan transliteration of Sanskrit syllables are conventional and do not affect the meaning. The phrase "bodhisattva who has attained great power" renders the epithet Mahāsthāmaprāpta by its functional description as given in the Tibetan, rather than supplying the proper name, since the Tibetan text itself does not use the name explicitly. The image of "ascending the mountain of nirvāṇa" and "dwelling in the house of the unconditioned" are standard Mahāyāna soteriological metaphors preserved as given.
- This passage is a continuation of the Nīlakaṇṭha Dhāraṇī (the dhāraṇī of Avalokiteśvara in his blue-throated form), consisting almost entirely of transliterated Sanskrit mantra syllables rendered phonetically into Tibetan script. The translation preserves them as reconstructed Sanskrit, following the convention established in the preceding passage. The closing line in Tibetan — rendering "This concludes the dhāraṇī of the noble Nīlakaṇṭha" — is the only non-mantra Tibetan in the passage and is translated directly. Several mantra phrases within

this section contain stock epithets drawn from Śaiva and Vaiṣṇava iconography applied to Avalokiteśvara: "Nārāyaṇa" (a name of Viṣṇu), "Vārāhamukha" (boar-faced, another Vaiṣṇava form), "Narasimhamukha" (man-lion-faced), and "Nīlakaṇṭha" (blue-throated, a Śaiva epithet) — all assimilated here into the bodhisattva's retinue of manifestations. The reconstruction of some syllable clusters is approximate given the phonetic Tibetan orthography.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.